Quotable Quote

I put for a general inclination of all mankind, a perpetual and restless desire of power after power that ceaseth only in death.- ***Hobbes***

In ***Hobbes***' words human beings are driven by their passions and use their intellectual capacity simply as a means to determine what will bring them the greatest pleasure or the least pain. ***Hobbes*** further adds that the object of man's desire is not to enjoy only once, and for one instant only, but to assure forever the way of his future desire. ***Hobbes*** is careful to also state that different people desire different forms of pleasure but there is one desire which is common in man – Power. Given that all are pleasure seekers, it must logically follow logically that all are power seekers. ***Hobbes*** thus regards human nature as utterly self-interested and self-regarding. Hence innately anti-social.

State of Nature

Hobbes in his theory of the state of nature provides a corollary method of understanding human behaviour..In the state of nature ***Hobbes*** argues, that it a condition of absolute liberty and equality. Absolute liberty since there would be no laws to constrain individuals and thus would have a right to everything; absolute equality because human beings have roughly equivalent physical and intellectual capabilities. ***Hobbes*** argues that in such a condition where everyone has a right to everything and all have equal capabilities in exercising their rights, all are subject to attacks from all. The state of nature is thus a state of war where survival remains the ultimate motive for human beings to acquire power. Thus in the state of nature everyone lives in constant fear of everyone else. It is thus by nature that human beings are by nature antisocial power seekers.

Social Contract

Hobbes' view of human nature has a profound impact on his political theory. Knowing the true nature of human beings, ***Hobbes*** puts forward a scientific theory of politics – the 'Social Contract'. The fundamental idea of the social contract is quite simple: The state is the result of a contract between human beings in which the scope and extent of the powers of the government are to be determined by an analysis of the terms of the contract. The state is created by mutual agreement or the consent of its members. As a result government is legitimate if it corresponds to what people have consented to.

Quotable Quote

"To do unto others before they do unto you" - ***Hobbes***

This is a very modern notion of the modern secular state which is contrary to medieval thought where the secular government exists by divine sanction. Such an idea was still employed by the Royalists who argued that the monarch ruled by divine right. The consent-contract flatly rejected this idea and on the contrary claimed that the government is legitimate only to the extent that people have consented to. The importance of ***Hobbes*** theory of social contract is that he believes that it is strictly a logical and scientific analysis of the state. He argues that human beings would consent only to that which rationally accords to their needs and desires.

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